partners. To ensure that the interventions result in sustainable impact, they have adopted a ‘cluster-based approach’ and provide multiple ‘interlinked activities’ in select clusters in ‘contiguous villages’ in select areas across the country. In this manner, on its own and through 450 partner organizations, the Trusts have reached out to millions of people in 170 districts of seventeen states, besides significantly contributing in the area of education and building ‘intellectual capital in the country’.

Making Changes

One of Ratan’s important priorities has been to strengthen the communities around the businesses of the various group companies, whether it is in India, the US or Africa. He says that it would be inadvisable to create a wide disparity between the living standards of the employees of a company and the populace in which the company is located. The company should be sensitive to this imperative. He adds: ‘So a corporation, I think, has to become part of community.’

In addition, Ratan has placed a premium on the outcomes of interventions. He says that it is critical to ensure that the assistance engenders an enduring change. There must be ‘sustainability of the community’, he says. This implies that after the assistance ends, the target group should have built on the benefits and overcome the drawbacks that were the reason for the extension of assistance in the first place.

Another shift in perspective is the increased emphasis on community approach. It focuses on projects that would benefit the larger society as opposed to individuals. He says, ‘Philanthropy in its true sense is not personal; it is humanity-based. It’s about the sensitivity you have to all the hardships that people face.’ Though in deserving cases individuals may receive aid, substantial assistance would be committed to research that would help fight a scourge itself. Elaborating on this approach, he says: ‘We believe [that] we can make a greater difference though large projects that serve mankind.’ This would involve addressing the problems holistically: for instance, making rice and bread iron-fortified to combat malnutrition in the marginalized sections of the society.

As a business leader who has accorded singular priority to the employment of expertise to optimize outcomes, Ratan has underlined the need to undertake projects in conjunction with lead entities in the field, a